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X to test using
Community Notes to find
the posts everyone likes

Elon Musk's X will begin experimenting with a new way to use Community Notes: its crowdsourcing fact-checking system, to highlight well-liked posts from users with different perspectives. On Thursday, the Community Notes X account [announced](#) the launch of a pilot test, where select contributors would be able to rate posts by answering questions about why they do or don't like that particular post.

The system is similar to how Community Notes fact-checking works — instead of simply allowing users to upvote or downvote posts for accuracy — something that could be easily gamed if like-minded contributors teamed up to promote their own views — Community Notes uses something called a “bridging algorithm.” This attempts to find consensus among people who don't usually share the same views.

IMAGE CREDITS: TECHCRUNCH

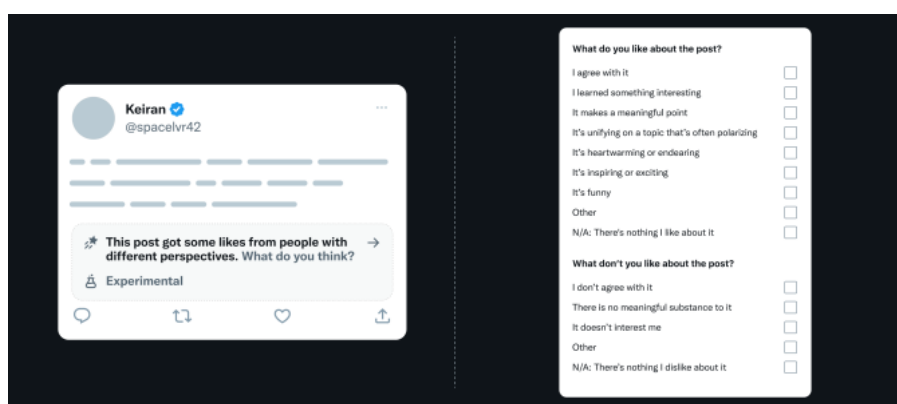


IMAGE CREDITS: X

If users whose opinions typically differ both agree that a fact-check is accurate, the note is published

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and made visible to the public. While X's system has been criticized for being too slow and unable to keep up with the massive amounts of misinformation that circulate on the platform, this same idea has since [been adopted by Meta](#) as a replacement for fact-checking.

Now X intends to see if Community Notes could help identify the best posts, too.

Starting today, the company says that a subset of Community Notes contributors will begin seeing a new callout in the product when a post is gaining attention in the form of Likes. Contributors will then be able to rate and provide feedback about the post, which will inform the algorithm if the post is being well-received by people with different perspectives.

In a [post](#) on the Community Notes X account, the company explains the experiment could bring awareness to "what resonates broadly."

"People often feel the world is divided, yet Community Notes shows people can agree, even on contentious topics. This experimental new feature seeks to uncover ideas, insights, and opinions that bridge perspectives," the post states. "Following the path we used to develop Community Notes, we're building in public with a small pilot so that this concept can be shaped by the people. We look forward to learning and iterating with you all as we do with Community Notes every day."

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Yes, Threads is running a fact-checking program, but the system isn't fully rolled out

Sarah Perez — 12:16 PM PST · February 16, 2024

[Threads](#), Meta's Twitter-like service and competitor to X, may be [distancing itself from politics](#), but that doesn't mean it won't try to tackle the misinformation that spreads across social media —

particularly in the lead-up to national elections. Following [user reports](#) of fact-checks spotted on the network, the company confirmed it's engaged with fact-checking organizations to address false information circulating on Threads, but has not fully rolled out direct fact-checking of Threads content as of yet.

Meta had [announced in December](#) that in early 2024 its [fact-checking partners](#) would be able to review and rate false content directly on Threads. In the meantime, Meta was only able to match existing fact-checks to "near-identical content on Threads," it said. From the looks of the users' reports of fact-checking now appearing on Threads, it's a case of *matched* ratings, not the more anticipated direct fact-checking of Threads content that people are seeing.

The company confirmed this was the case, telling TechCrunch that it hasn't finalized the ability for fact-checkers to rate content directly on Threads yet, but would soon.

Post by @culturecrave

[View on Threads](#)

Threads users [had noticed that warning labels appeared on posts](#) — in one case, both as an interstitial over a false AI-generated video and as a pop-up that appeared from the bottom of the screen.

The warning message reads "False Information," followed by an explanation that "the same false

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information was reviewed in another thread by fact-checkers. There may be small differences.” It also then noted that “independent fact-checkers say this information has no basis in fact,” and documents which fact-checking sources came to this conclusion.

TC

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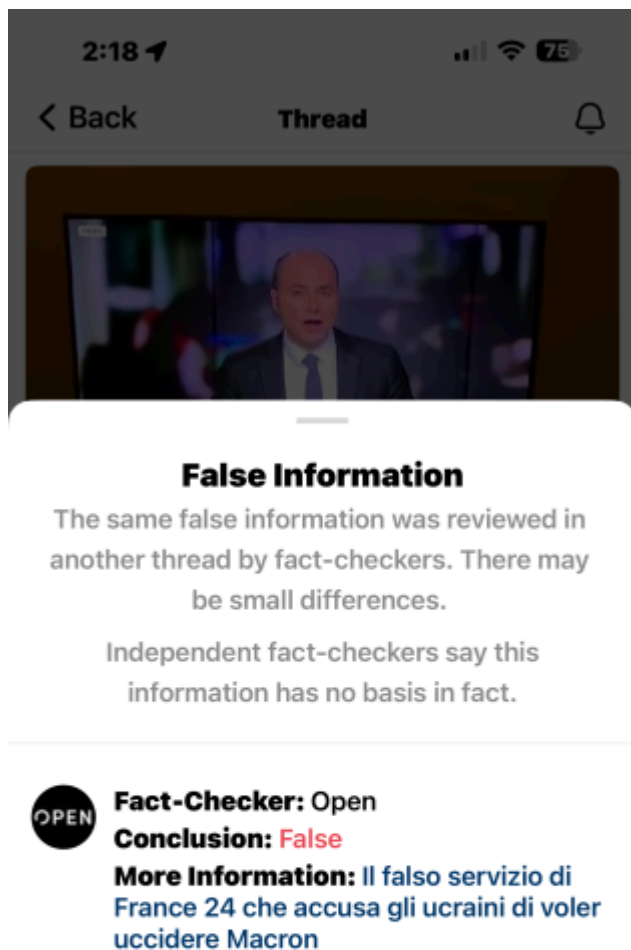
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Below this, users can read the name of the fact-checking organizations, and the sources’

conclusion — e.g. “False” — along with additional information about the content and why it’s false.

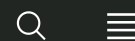


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generated, the fact-checking organizations [both state](#).

In our tests, the fact-check did initially hide the Threads post with the video but offered a “See Post” button to click through and view it. You could optionally tap on “See why” if you wanted to know

why it was being hidden for false information. The feature feels a bit underdeveloped, however, as the links to fact-checking websites only worked on mobile, not desktop, and the informational warning below the video, once viewed, was in small text that could be easily missed.

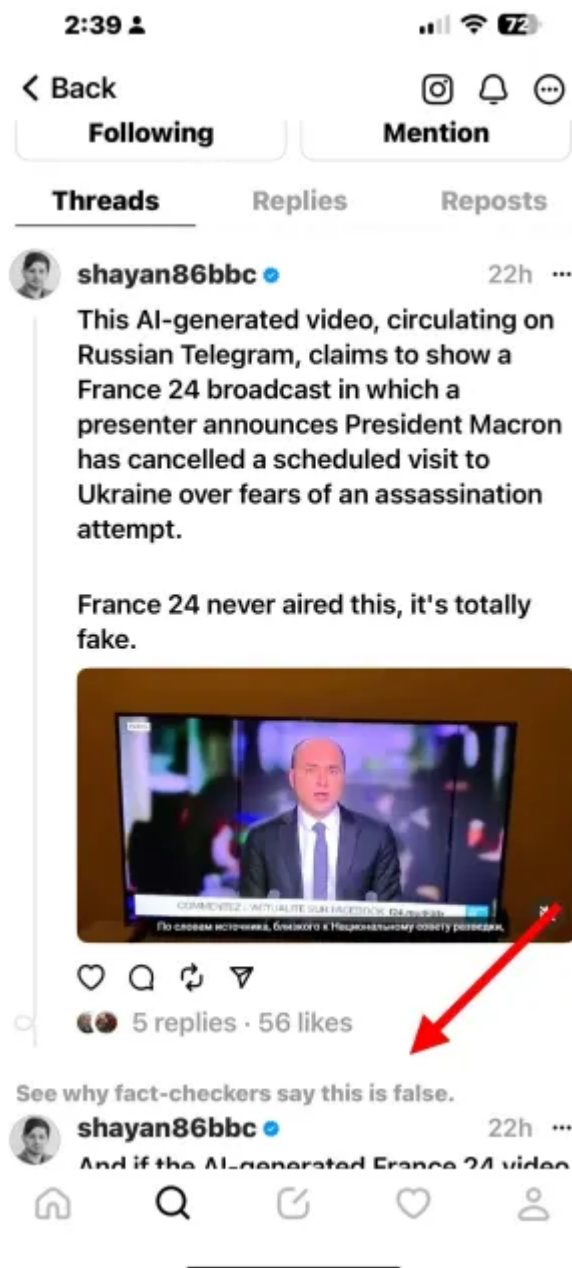


IMAGE CREDITS: THREADS SCREENSHOT

Though full fact-checking capabilities have not yet rolled out to Threads, when they do the feature will differentiate Threads from its rival X, where fact-checks are now largely managed via crowdsourcing. With X's Community Notes ([originally called Birdwatch](#) when the company was known as Twitter), independent volunteers fact-check posts and add additional context or corrections. The system's algorithm then attempts

to find a consensus among people who don't usually share the same views. If both sides agree a fact check is warranted, the Community Note goes live. Meanwhile, the X team can't edit or modify the notes, the [company's website explains](#). Instead, X only takes action on posts that violate its rules, terms or privacy policy.

Elon Musk has championed the use of Community Notes since [acquiring](#) the company in 2022, having [believed](#) that Twitter's former team was guilty of left-wing bias and censorship. However, [a ProPublica report found](#) that Community Notes hasn't yet sufficiently scaled to address the misinformation circulating on X about the Israel-Hamas war. What's more, debunked claims were often spread by Verified accounts with blue checks, giving them higher visibility, it said.

Meta is clearly taking a more cautious approach to news and the potential for misinformation.

Instagram head Adam Mosseri said last year that [Threads will not "amplify news" on its platform](#), upsetting journalists and news consumers who were looking for a Twitter alternative. The company also made good on those promises last week when it announced it would [no longer proactively surface political content in its recommendations](#) across both Threads and Instagram. News and politics may still appear in [the app's new trends feature](#), "today's topics," however.

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Consumer News Editor | [X](#) [🦋](#) [@](#) [in](#)

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

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IMAGE CREDITS: TECHCRUNCH

APPS

X's crowdsourced fact-checking system will now let contributors consider opposing viewpoints

Sarah Perez — 7:37 AM PDT · September 15, 2023

X (formerly Twitter) [this week changed](#) how its crowdsourced fact-checking Community Notes

feature works. In the new design, users will be able to review all the notes that have been proposed as annotations to an X post, rather than just the one note they're currently reviewing. In other words, it will allow contributors to consider other notes before leaving their rating — and possibly, could convince them to change their mind.

It's a subtle tweak but one that could influence Community Notes contributors to consider different viewpoints, rather than simply agreeing with the crowd that a note is helpful — which means the note is displayed publicly to X's users below the post as a crowdsourced fact-check.

X says this change was needed as “it's important that contributors have as much helpful information as possible,” when rating notes.

When rating a note, it's important that contributors have as much helpful information available as possible. Starting today, when contributors tap “Rate it” on a note, they'll be taken to a page listing all note proposals, instead of just the note they're looking at.

This way,... pic.twitter.com/gjia4jUQ25

— Community Notes (@CommunityNotes)
[September 12, 2023](#)

However, it's also a way to put alternative points of view in front of contributors, which could change their thinking or add to confusion over which of the proposed notes is actually the most helpful and the most accurate. Feedback on X was largely positive over the update, but it remains to be seen in practice if this will lead to more contributors possibly changing their minds and selecting other, alternative notes as more helpful instead of the one they're currently viewing.

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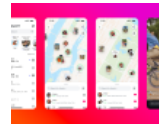
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Even in the example X provided, there are two notes presented where both could be considered helpful. One corrects misinformation in a tweet by noting that whales are, in fact, mammals, while the other says a note isn't needed because the account is a parody account. Both notes are actually true — but the latter could encourage Community Note contributors to remove the added context from a tweet.

This could get more complicated if the parody account was of a political nature and the statements that “don’t need correction” are misinformation one side is trying to spread. Removing the note in that case, simply because it’s a parody account, could be more harmful if users didn’t bother to check the account’s bio where the account disclosed its parody nature.

Community Notes first launched as [Birdwatch in 2021](#), prior to Elon Musk’s acquisition of the network formerly known as Twitter. One of the platform’s more innovative features, the system uses an algorithm that looks to find consensus across groups where there are differing points of view before it highlights the crowdsourced fact-checks to other users. In addition, Community Notes contributors first have to prove they’re capable by rating notes as helpful or not helpful and earning points when their rating ends up in alignment with the larger community’s final decision.

The system has continued to be updated under Musk’s ownership, having recently launched [Community Notes for videos](#), among other changes [designed to streamline the process](#) and [address low-quality contributions](#).

Topics: [Apps](#) [community_notes](#) [social media](#) [Twitter](#)

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Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor | [X](#) [🦋](#) [@](#) [in](#)

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